



States

WEST BENGAL

Singh & DANCE

Win or lose, BJP warhorse Jaswant Singh takes to the hills like they are his own

| By Abhijit Dasgupta in Darjeeling |

Elections are serious business, but in the Darjeeling hills, a campaign rally is more like one massive street party. Especially if the candidate happens to be senior BJP leader Jaswant Singh. Thousands cram into whatever space is available and before the final speaker, the Gorkha Janamukti Morcha (GJM) President, Bimal Gurung takes the podium in the style of an opera conductor, young women break into dance and men with *khukris* soon join in to a recorded Gorkha musical rendition of "Let Jaswant win, *jai* BJP" and ending with a catchy "Only Bimal, vote for *kamal*".

Seventy-year-old Singh, who is more used to the politics of negotiations and backroom manoeuvres, moves down from the dais and joins his newfound fans in shaking a leg even as pretty young girls line up to give him a peck on the cheek. His opponents see him as an outsider but with one wave of his hand, he tells the faithful, "If I win, I shall come and stay with you, build a house and enrol myself in the voters' list here. I will live long enough to get your job done. That is the only challenge now left in my life."

It's just as well that he was in the army. Waking up at 3 a.m., the man, who stands erect despite a serious equestrian accident long back, tying a *khada* (a Gorkha shawl) tightly around his waist to lessen the pain, works for more than 18 hours a day. Sometimes, he indulges in public relations by having a haircut in a tiny Kalimpong barber shop and engages in small talk at the *chourasta*. But he tells rallies, "I

will learn Gorkhali in a month and talk to you in your language." For the Rajput soldier, the biggest relief is that the cheering people believe him.

But his opponents, mainly in the plains, are unsparing. Said Jibesh Sarkar, his rival from the CPI(M), "What does he know of the hills? He is welcome to stay here as a guest or visit as a tourist. Even his party has not categorically promised Gorkhaland. He is just mouthing platitudes to get votes and then spend time in Delhi."

Singh laughs this away. "Look, I do not talk about my rivals. This is the cleanest campaign I have seen in the 11 elections that I have been part of and I am going to stick to that. But all I will say is that there was no pre-

meditated design to get this nomination. I was literally plucked from the heart of the desert and put in the lap of the Himalayas. I see the hand of God here. I am at peace with myself."

However, nobody quite knows what exactly went on behind the scenes before Singh was suddenly chosen as the candidate for Darjeeling. A BJP leader from the hills, Dawa Sherpa, had already filed his nomination papers before he had to withdraw in Singh's favour. The general secretary of the Morcha, Roshan Giri, said, "Sherpa was a weak candidate. We wanted someone who could articulate our demands nationally. Jaswantji was a logical choice."

Singh explains. "I had told L.K.



WITH GURUNG'S HELP, SINGH IS HAVING A BALL IN DARJEELING